ascentium

Startup toolkit

United Arab Emirates

Setting up and running a free zone or mainland company in Dubai or Abu Dhabi.

Inside: the company at a glance · your first 90 days · the annual compliance calendar · are you an SME? · the documents to gather · how Ascentium helps

Mock toolkit prepared for a concept prototype. Not legal, tax or financial advice.
Information as at November 2026. Verify figures with the relevant authority before relying on them.

1. Your company at a glance

Item	What applies
Entity	Free zone company (FZ-LLC / FZCO) or mainland LLC
Licensing	A trade licence from the free zone authority or the emirate's economic department
Ownership	100% foreign ownership is available for most activities
Corporate tax	0% on taxable income up to AED 375,000 and 9% above, with special rules for qualifying free zone persons
VAT	5%; registration is mandatory above AED 375,000 of taxable supplies
Beneficial owners	An Ultimate Beneficial Owner register must be kept and filed

Good to know

Choosing between free zone and mainland depends on where your customers are. Free zone companies generally need a mainland partner or branch to trade directly onshore.

2. Your first 90 days

Tick these off in order. Your Ascentium dashboard tracks each one and Ascentia will remind you before anything falls due.

- ☐ **Pick the jurisdiction and activity**
  The licence activity decides the free zone, office and visa options.
- ☐ **Obtain the trade licence**
  Submit shareholder KYC, the business plan and the lease or flexi-desk agreement.
- ☐ **Register for corporate tax**
  Every taxable person must register with the Federal Tax Authority.
- ☐ **Open a business account**
  Expect enhanced due diligence; allow several weeks.
- ☐ **Apply for visas**
  Establishment card, investor visa, then employee visas within your quota.
- ☐ **Check VAT**
  Register once supplies pass the mandatory threshold.

3. Annual compliance calendar

The recurring obligations most small private companies meet each year. Exact dates depend on your financial year-end and on notices issued by the authorities.

Obligation	When	Authority
Trade licence renewal	Every year on the licence anniversary	Free zone or DED
Corporate tax return	Within 9 months of the end of the tax period	Federal Tax Authority
VAT returns	Quarterly or monthly, 28 days after the period ends	Federal Tax Authority
UBO register	Keep current; update within 15 days of a change	Licensing authority
Audited accounts	Annually, where the free zone or tax rules require	Free zone / FTA

4. Are you an SME?

Under UAE Cabinet Resolution No. 22 of 2016, SMEs are enterprises with up to 200 employees in trading and services (250 in industry) and annual turnover up to AED 200 million in services or AED 250 million in trading and industry. Dubai SME also applies its own definition.

Ascentium SME pricing

If your company, assessed together with any linked group companies, meets the official SME definition above, you qualify for Ascentium SME fares and the AI platform. Larger groups are served by Ascentium for Enterprise at ascentium.com.

5. Documents to gather

- ☐ **Passport and visa copy (or entry stamp) for every shareholder**
- ☐ **Proof of address**
- ☐ **Proposed trade names (usually three options)**
- ☐ **Licence activity and short business plan**
- ☐ **For corporate shareholders: attested incorporation documents**

6. How Ascentium helps

AI compliance dashboard	A live compliance score for every entity, with each filing, deadline and document in one view.
Ascentia, AI voice assistant	Ask about your status, deadlines or a change, 24/7, and get a qualified expert when judgement is needed.
Premium Economy fare	Licence application support, corporate tax registration, bookkeeping and your corporate tax return from AED 14,900 a year, excluding licence fees.
Switching is easy	Moving from another provider? We take over registers and records and file the change for you.